

# USA F-1 Student Visa Guide

## Visa Type

The F-1 Student Visa is the most common visa for academic study at U.S. colleges, universities, seminaries, conservatories, academic high schools, and language training programs. The M-1 visa applies to vocational or non-academic study.

## Required Documents

- Valid passport, valid at least 6 months beyond intended stay
- Form I-20, Certificate of Eligibility, issued by your SEVIS-approved school
- DS-160 Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application confirmation page
- SEVIS I-901 fee payment receipt (currently 350 USD for F-1 students)
- MRV visa application fee payment receipt (currently 185 USD)
- Passport-style photo meeting U.S. visa specifications
- Proof of financial support such as bank statements, sponsor letters, or scholarship award letters
- Academic transcripts, diplomas, and standardized test scores such as TOEFL, IELTS, SAT, GRE, or GMAT
- Evidence of ties to home country such as property, family, or a job offer after graduation

## Financial Requirements

Applicants must demonstrate sufficient funds to cover the full first year of study, including tuition and living expenses, as listed on Form I-20. Average annual costs range from approximately 20,000 to 60,000 USD depending on the institution and state. Funds may come from personal savings, family sponsors, scholarships, assistantships, or education loans. If a sponsor is providing funds, an affidavit of support along with the sponsor's own bank statements is typically required.

## Processing Time

After the visa interview, processing typically takes 3 to 5 weeks, though this varies by consulate. Interview wait times themselves can range from a few days to several months depending on the embassy location and time of year. Students should apply for their visa as early as 120 days before their program start date, though the visa will not be issued more than 120 days in advance.

## Application Steps

- Receive Form I-20 from your SEVIS-approved U.S. institution after being admitted
- Pay the SEVIS I-901 fee online before scheduling your interview
- Complete the DS-160 online nonimmigrant visa application form
- Pay the MRV visa application fee at a designated bank
- Schedule a visa interview at the nearest U.S. Embassy or Consulate

- Gather all required supporting documents
- Attend the in-person visa interview, typically 10 to 15 minutes long
- Wait for passport return with visa stamp, usually within 3 to 5 business days of approval
- Enter the United States no earlier than 30 days before the program start date

## **Interview Requirements**

An in-person interview at a U.S. Embassy or Consulate is mandatory for almost all F-1 applicants.

Common questions include why the applicant chose their specific program and school, how they will fund their studies, what their plans are after graduation, and what ties they have to their home country. Officers are assessing whether the applicant is a genuine student who intends to return home after completing their studies.

## **Work Rights**

F-1 students may work on campus for up to 20 hours per week while school is in session and full time during official school breaks. Off-campus employment generally requires specific authorization such as Curricular Practical Training (CPT) during studies or Optional Practical Training (OPT) after graduation, which allows up to 12 months of work authorization, extendable by 24 months for STEM graduates.

## **Common FAQs**

- What is SEVIS? It is the Student and Exchange Visitor Information System, a database that tracks international students throughout their stay, requiring a one-time fee before the visa interview.
- Can I bring my family? Spouses and children may apply for F-2 dependent visas, though F-2 dependents generally cannot work in the United States.
- What happens if my visa is denied? There is no mandatory waiting period before reapplying, but applicants should address the reasons cited for the prior denial.